*Happenings in Handmade*

A CCI initiative

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# FROM BANDHANI TO SUNGUDI





With deep cultural roots and unique histories, Bandhani and Sungudi are both ancient Indian tie-dye textile traditions that showcase distinct regional variations and adaptations.

Bandhani, from the Sanskrit word "bandh" or "bandhna" meaning to tie, dates back to the Indus Valley Civilization. Its distinctive dot patterns are seen in 6th-century Ajanta Cave paintings. Bandhani today is associated with the states of Gujarat and Rajasthan.



Five hundred years ago, the Saurashtrian community from Gujarat migrated south, settling in the Madurai region of Tamil Nadu. The travellers brought with them their tie-dye skills, an artistic tradition that then flourished under the patronage of the Nayak dynasty.



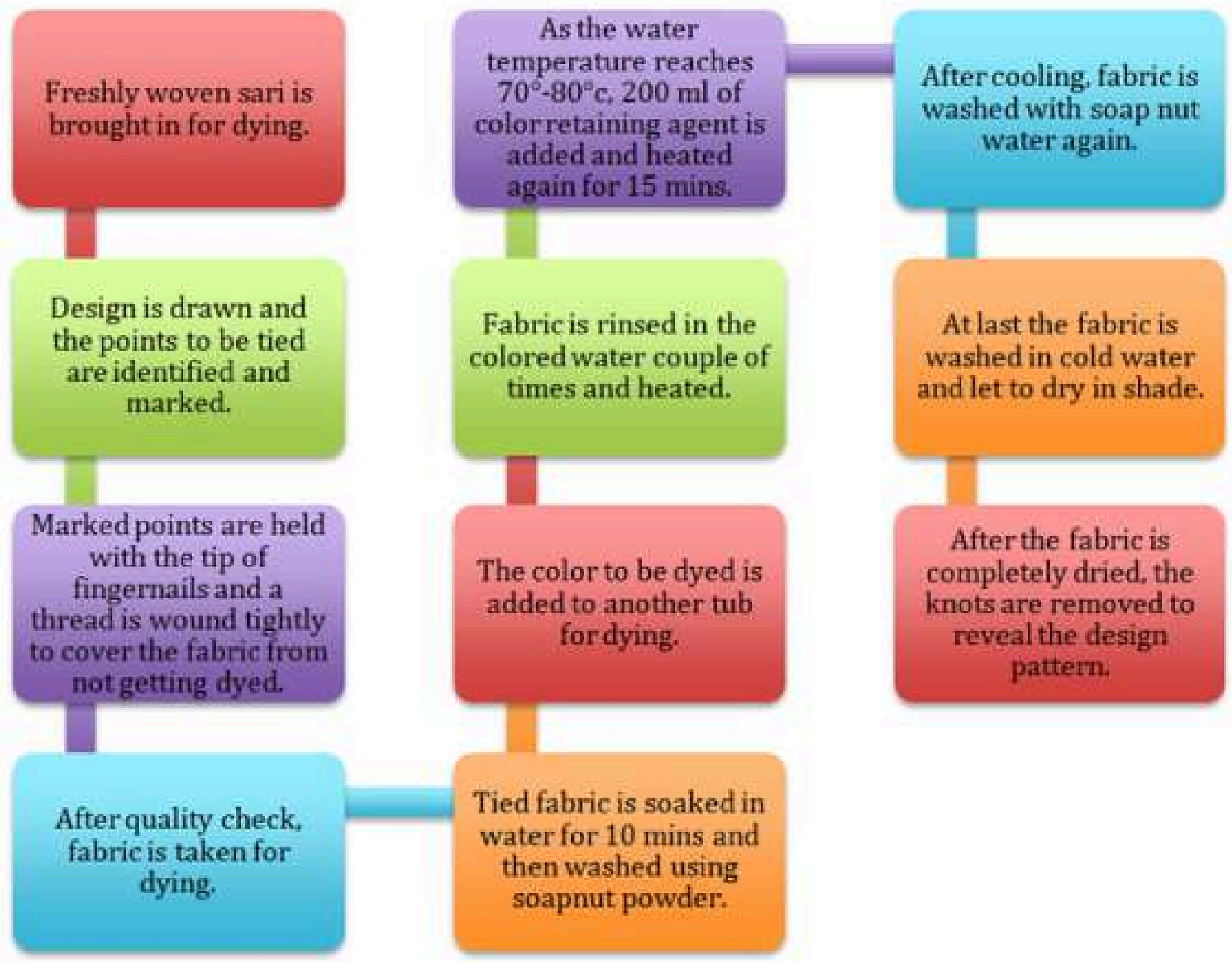
The term used by them, "Sungudi," originates from the Sanskrit word "sunnam", meaning "round," aptly describing the dots that adorn the fabric. In this technique, thousands of tiny knots are meticulously tied on cotton fabric before it is dyed. These knots resist the dye, revealing the characteristic white dotted patterns once the threads are removed.







Creating a Sungudi saree is a labour-intensive process demanding skill and patience. Traditionally men dyed the hand-woven sarees while women meticulously worked on tying the knots around mustard or peppercorn seeds.



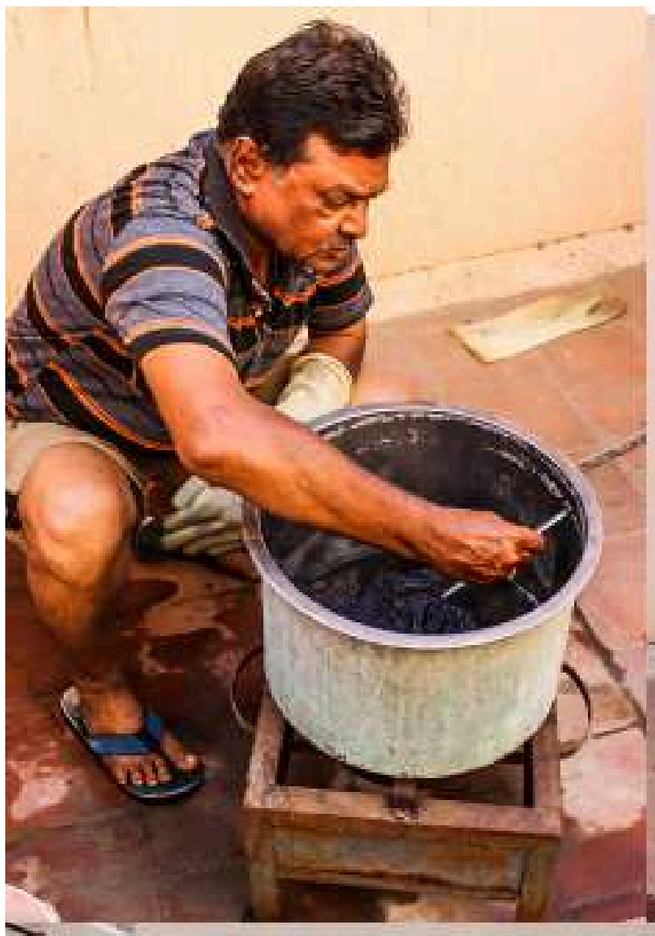

*Please read 'dying' as 'dyeing'*



















The patterns were inspired by celestial constellations and South Indian kolam designs. Natural dyes extracted from plants and other organic materials were traditionally used, making Sungudi an "eco-friendly saree" in its purest form. In fact, the famous "Madura Red" dye, renowned for its colour-fastness, was a product of Madurai's innovative dyeing techniques, utilizing local plants like the *chay* root and water from the Vaigai river.



*Red dye was got from the root of the* Chay *plant or* Oldenlandia umbellata

The traditional Sungudi craft has faced challenges from the rise of power looms, synthetic dyes and block printing, which offer faster and cheaper alternatives. However, with support from organizations like the Crafts Council of India and the government's Geographical Indication (GI) tag for "Madurai Sungudi" in 2005, efforts are being made to revive and preserve this art form.

The story of Sungudi sarees is a testament to the resilience of traditional crafts, the artistry of skilled weavers, and the enduring beauty of a cultural heritage passed down through generations.

# *Credits*

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